The Rules of Vardolin

Vardolin is a trading game for two to four players set in a river valley. Each player leads a family of boat traders who carry goods between the villages along the river. The family that earns the most lantern points by the end of the twelfth season wins the game.

The Rules of Vardolin are the same for two, three or four players. Only the number of barges each player receives at the start depends on the number of players, as described in Unit 1.

Unit 1. Setting up the board

OBJ-01-01 Describe how the river board is assembled.

OBJ-01-02 State how many barges each player receives for a given number of players.

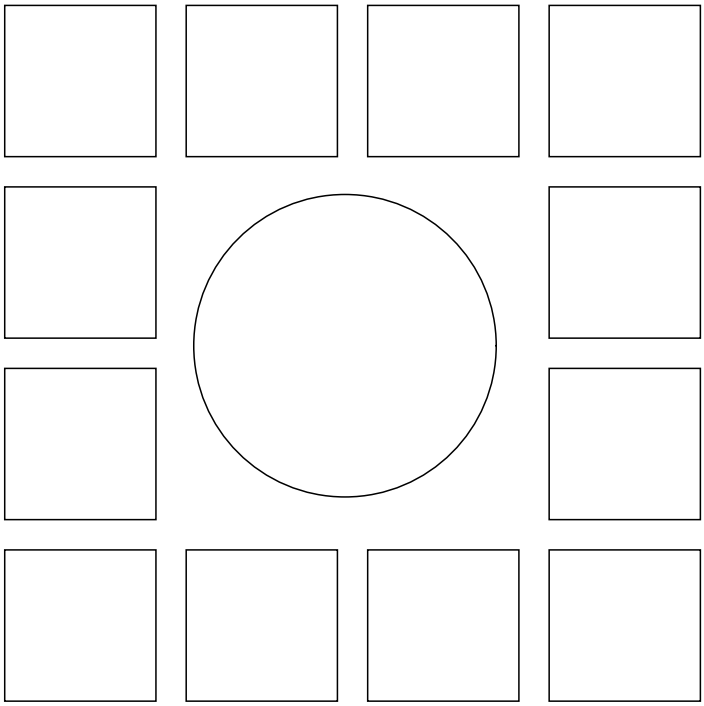
OBJ-01-03 Explain how the market track is prepared before the first season.

The board is a ring of twelve river tiles placed around the Lantern Isle, a round central tile that never moves. Each river tile shows one village and one landing stage. The tiles are shuffled face down and then turned over one by one, starting from the tile marked with a heron and continuing clockwise. A river tile that shows a waterfall must not be placed next to another waterfall; if this happens, the second waterfall tile is moved to the next free position and the remaining tiles are placed after it.

Each player chooses a colour and takes the barges of that colour. In a game for two players each player receives five barges; in a game for three players, four barges; and in a game for four players, three barges. Barges that are not used are returned to the box and play no part in the game. Every player then places one barge on any landing stage that is not yet occupied, beginning with the youngest player and continuing in turn-order.

The market track runs along the edge of the board and has four rows, one for each resource: reed, amber, salt and wool. A white price marker is placed on the third space of every row. During the game these markers move up and down as resources are bought and sold, so the price of a resource always shows how scarce it has become. The market track is never reset during a game, not even between seasons.

Finally, each player takes a trading screen and two reed, one amber and one wool from the general supply. Resources are always kept behind the screen, so the other players can see how many resources a player holds in total but not which ones. The general supply holds all resources that are not owned by a player, and it is replenished at the start of every season. Resources returned to the general supply during a season stay there until it is replenished again.



Unit 2. Taking a turn

OBJ-02-01 List the three phases of a turn in the correct order.

OBJ-02-02 Explain how a barge moves along the river and when it must stop.

OBJ-02-03 Describe what a player may do at a landing stage.

A game lasts twelve seasons, and in every season each player takes exactly one turn. The turn-order is fixed at the start of the game and does not change, except when a player builds a trade-post, as described in Unit 3. A turn always has three phases, which are played in this order: the tide phase, the sailing phase and the landing phase.

In the tide phase the active player rolls the tide die. The die shows a number from one to three, or a crescent. A number tells the player how many river tiles each of their barges may move in the sailing phase. A crescent means that the river is calm: the player may not sail at all, but instead takes one resource of their choice from the general supply.

In the sailing phase the player may move each of their barges up to the number of tiles shown by the tide die. Barges always move clockwise; a barge may never sail against the current. A barge must stop at a waterfall tile, even if it could move further, and it must also stop when it reaches a tile that holds a barge of another player. Two barges of the same player may share a tile. A player may choose not to move a barge at all, which is often useful when a valuable village lies just ahead.

In the landing phase the player chooses one of their barges and takes one action at the landing stage on which it stands. There are three possible actions: buying resources from the village, selling resources to the village, or building a trade-post. A barge that did not move in the sailing phase may still be chosen for the landing phase. The other barges of the player take no action in this turn.

Page 2 of the score sheet records every action taken in the landing phase, so the players can check later which villages were visited most often. Keeping this record is optional in a friendly game, but it is required in a tournament. In a tournament the score sheet is signed by all players at the end of the game.

Unit 3. Trading resources

OBJ-03-01 Calculate the cost of buying resources at a given market price.

OBJ-03-02 Explain how buying and selling move the price markers.

OBJ-03-03 State the conditions for building a trade-post.

When a player buys resources at a landing stage, they pay the price shown on the market track for each resource they buy, using silver coins. A player may buy at most three resources in one action, and all of them must be of the kind produced by that village. After the purchase the price marker of that resource moves up by one space for every resource bought, so the next player will pay more. If the marker is already on the highest space, it stays there.

When a player sells resources, the village pays the current price for each resource sold, and the price marker then moves down by one space for every resource sold. A village only buys the resources it does not

produce itself. Selling four or more resources of the same kind in one action is called a flood, and after a flood the price marker drops by one extra space. Experienced players use floods to make a resource cheaper just before they buy it themselves in a later turn.

A trade-post is a small wooden house that a player places on a village. Building a trade-post costs one reed, one amber, one salt and one wool, and only one trade-post may stand on each village. A player who owns a trade-post on a village receives one silver coin from the bank whenever another player buys or sells at that village. In addition, the player who builds a trade-post moves to the first place in the turn-order from the next season on, and all other players move one place back.

Open negotiation between players is allowed at any time, but a deal is only binding while it is being carried out. Players may exchange resources and silver coins behind their screens, but they may never exchange barges or trade-posts. A promise about a future turn can be broken without penalty, which makes careful negotiation an important part of the game.

Unit 4. Scoring and the end of the game

OBJ-04-01 List the sources of lantern points at the end of the game.

OBJ-04-02 Apply the tie-break rules to decide the winner.

The game ends after the turn of the last player in the twelfth season. The players then remove their screens and count their lantern points. Each trade-post is worth three lantern points, and a player who owns trade-posts on two neighbouring villages scores two bonus points for the pair. Every five silver coins are worth one lantern point; remaining coins are worth nothing.

Resources left behind the screen are also counted. Each set of four different resources, one reed, one amber, one salt and one wool, is worth two lantern points. Single resources that do not complete a set are worth nothing, so players often try to sell them in their last turn instead of keeping them.

Finally, the player whose barges stand closest to the Lantern Isle receives the lantern bonus of four points. Distance is counted in river tiles from the heron tile, and for every player only the barge that has travelled furthest is used. If two players are equally close, both receive the full bonus.

If two or more players have the same number of lantern points, the tie is broken by the number of trade-posts. If they are still tied, the player who is later in the turn-order wins, because that player had fewer chances to act in the final season. Players who remain tied after both rules share the victory.